



From Initiatives to Infrastructure

What Arterial could build — and offer the art world — the day
it owns the platform beneath everything it already does.

A Polymash proposal

For discussion with Scott

June 2026

WHAT THIS UNLOCKS

Imagine What Arterial Could Offer

White-label galleries

Spin up a branded online gallery for a partner in an afternoon — their look, their artists, our infrastructure underneath.

Customized online exhibitions

Every show its own design, parameters, and story — sliders, dimensions on or off, animated storytelling. Not one rigid template.

Partnerships as living collaborations

Turn relationships into running, visible exhibitions and shared programs — not one-off favors that disappear after the event.

Infrastructure for the smaller players

Give small galleries and artists who have no online infrastructure a way to submit, exhibit, and be discovered — through us.

A suite of **services** Arterial could offer — not another one-off project. Today, we can build none of them.

ONE THING STANDS IN THE WAY

We Rent And Stitch — We Don't Own

Everything Arterial runs on today is **rented and stitched together** — a sprawl of tools that don't talk to each other. Some of it can stay (WordPress and the content tools aren't going anywhere). But none of it is an owned home for the thing that matters most:

Artwork Archive

WordPress + plugins

Ghost + Elfsight

Airtable

ActiveCampaign

Paperform submissions

InstaPage

Thinkific

StoryChief

Convertbox

Zealous

n8n scripts

one-off websites

Arterial's artists, artworks, and exhibitions have no platform of their own. Build that one layer — and everything on the last slide is on the table.

WHAT EVERYTHING ALREADY RUNS ON

Arterial's Real Asset: Its Artists & Artworks

Almost everything Arterial makes draws on the same thing: our **collection of artists and artworks**. Built over years of open calls, grants, and exhibitions.

10,000+

artworks

1,000s

of artists



THE SHARED CORE

Artists

Artwork

Submissions

Exhibitions

Partnerships

Not Real Art, Artsville, the NRA Grant, the exhibition series, Sugar Press — all pull from this. **Own it, and everything downstream is ours to shape.**

THE MOVE

Own The Core, And Two Things Happen

ONE OPERATING SYSTEM

Every initiative plugs into one owned substrate

Art House pulls artists from it. Artsville shows exhibitions from it. The Grant feeds it. The *next* initiative launches **on** it — instead of being rebuilt from scratch in yet another tool.

ONE MATURE INSTITUTION

The portfolio finally reads as a real organization

An owned platform is what turns a constellation of projects into a capable institution with its own infrastructure — one place the whole portfolio finally connects.

The art world's own value is consolidating around exactly this — owned platforms plus proprietary data. In 2025, Beowolff Capital bought Artnet and merged it with Artsy into a single data-and-AI ecosystem. Platform + data *is* the asset.

THE WHOLE LIFECYCLE, OWNED END-TO-END

One Seamless Flow — Not Six Rented Tools

Baked-in submissions & open calls

Partners run their own branded calls; submissions land enriched. Replaces Paperform + Airtable.

Multi-curator judging

Score submissions, shortlist, select artworks, and issue grants — together. Replaces Zealous.

Configurable exhibitions

Per-show design and parameters — dimensions, sliders, storytelling. Not one rigid format.

Labels & catalogs as a service

Auto-generate wall labels, didactics, and print/digital catalogs from each record.

QR: wall to phone

Scan a physical label → full artist record, more works, and an inquiry path.

Partner analytics

Engagement, dwell, geography — insight a small gallery has never had.

Open call to gallery wall to grant award — in one system we control, replacing Paperform, Airtable, Zealous, and the manual work in between.

THINGS WE'RE NOT EVEN DOING YET

And Capabilities The Rented Stack Could Never Touch

Visual, vector-driven discovery

Surface works by color, style, region, or artist — the platform understands how art relates.

AI curator

"A show in greens, under 36 inches" — propose themed exhibitions from the archive.

Relationship graph

Artist ↔ artwork ↔ exhibition ↔ partner — powering "more like this" everywhere.

Per-exhibition radio & podcasts

AI-produced audio about a show — on our own engine, per exhibition.

Artist self-service profiles

Portable portfolios that keep themselves current, with automated re-engagement.

Conversational, attribute search

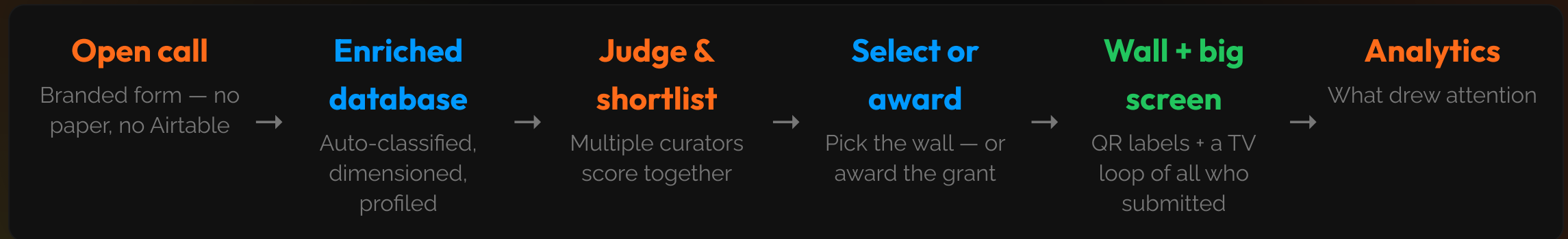
Designer-grade: "works for a blue hotel corridor, under 36 inches" — from our own data.

This is the upside of owning the data *and* the AI — a whole class of things we've never even tried, impossible on rented gallery software.

MADE CONCRETE

A Partner Gallery — Or A Grant — Powered By Us

A small gallery, a partner program, or our own grant runs end-to-end on one platform — white-labeled as theirs:



The same flow runs our grants and competitions. The multi-curator judging step replaces Zealous — judges score submissions and award grantees in one place, instead of paying for a separate tool we keep having to switch on and off.

A 12-piece room feels like a 200-artist exhibition — submissions, judging, display, and analytics, all one platform configured for them.

FROM DISCOVERY TO INCOME

The Loop Only We Can Close

Owning the substrate lets discovery flow all the way to **sustainable revenue** — and it amplifies artists rather than walling anyone out.



↳ Revenue funds artists *and* Arterial — which draws in more artists. A flywheel, not a toll booth.

You can't route discovery into print commerce through a gallery plugin and a paper form. The owned platform is what connects the two ends.

THE ASSET IS ALREADY IN THE BUILDING

Thousands Of Artists, Waiting To Be Reached

WHAT WE ALREADY HAVE

An audience of artists built over years of open calls and grants. They opted in. They submitted. They care about what Arterial does. **They're not gone — they're un-reached.**

WHAT THE PLATFORM DOES

Makes staying in touch **systematic**: self-service artist profiles that keep themselves current, automated re-engagement, and discovery that pulls artists back into Arterial's orbit on their own.

The cheapest growth Arterial has isn't new reach — it's re-activating the relationships already sitting in our own collection.

WHEN WE CHOOSE, NOT BEFORE

Partnerships Become A Switch We Control

Because the platform is **multi-tenant by design**, a partner instance is a *configuration* — not a rebuild. The infrastructure flexes to whoever Arterial chooses to work with, whenever it makes sense.

No commitment to "become a software vendor." Just the option to extend what we run — to a CodaWorks collaboration, a public-art project, a regional gallery — at the press of a switch.

ONE ENGINE, MANY TENANTS

Arterial & Not Real Art

Artsville USA

CodaWorks · public art

+ any partner, when we choose

WHY THIS IS REAL

Proven Pieces, Built To Be Owned

NOT STARTING FROM ZERO

The enrichment pipeline, the 10,000-artwork dataset, and the vector engine that understands how artworks relate **already run in production**. This is assembling proven pieces — not a moonshot.

BUILT TO BE OWNED, NOT BABYSAT

Industry best practices, fully documented, handoff-able. **No key-person dependency** — Arterial owns and operates it. The platform is an asset on the books, not a person on call.

Two reasons this isn't a gamble: the hard parts **already work** — and whatever we build, **Arterial keeps**.

WHAT WE'RE ASKING

Agree On The Principle. Fund The First Step.

THE PRINCIPLE

An owned platform, built on the artists and artworks Arterial already has, is worth pursuing — and the first move is to replace rented Artwork Archive with our own production-ready system.

THE FIRST PHASE — A FUNDED POLYMASH SCOPING & FOUNDATION ENGAGEMENT

Migration plan & roadmap

Design docs and a roadmap to replace Artwork Archive — porting our submissions into one owned, consolidated database.

A working proof of concept

An embeddable gallery on our own infrastructure (Next.js + Supabase) — the first real replacement piece, live on our data.

A promotable site

A site explaining what the platform is, what it does, and who benefits — inviting inquiries, so Scott has something to promote now.

Concrete, promotable deliverables — not a demo gimmick — before any larger build commitment.

The question isn't whether to build it.

It's whether Arterial keeps renting its future — or finally owns the thing every one of its initiatives already depends on.



Sources & References

A vision deck — these back the few external claims

Art-market value is consolidating around owned platforms + proprietary data. In 2025 Beowolff Capital acquired Artnet (~\$73.7M) and merged it with Artsy into one data-and-AI ecosystem. — Artnet News; ARTnews.

The rented gallery layer offers one rigid exhibition format — the limitation this platform removes. — Artwork Archive public exhibition/feature documentation; Arterial team production use.

Vector-embedding visual similarity is the established technique behind the platform's "how artworks relate" discovery — the same approach Polymash already runs in production in the Intersect curator.

Full URLs, quotes, and retrieval dates: `research/sources.md` in the idea folder.